battalions in Tawang, one in Bomdila, and one battalion less a company for both Teju and Hayuliang.[55]

In the event, the Army's deployments proved insufficient for coping with the Chinese offensive in October–November 1962. It simply did not have enough troops that were equipped, trained, and acclimatised to function effectively on the Himalayan front.[56] In other words, the Indian Army was ill prepared for a border conflict with China. Nor was the Air Force prepared for war with China. It is true that offensive air power was not employed during the war due to the fear of retaliatory bombardment of vital population and industrial and communication centres and the calculation that an air war would disrupt the Air Force's supply missions to the otherwise isolated forward posts. However, the fact remains that the bulk of the Air Force was deployed against Pakistan, and the government was reluctant to weaken its defences on that front by redeploying fighters and fighter bombers to the eastern sector where they could have played an important offensive role. Worse, the Air Force not only lacked suitable transport aircraft that could operate at the Himalayan heights until the acquisition of a handful of Antonov-12s in 1961, but it also did not have the older generation of aircraft in sufficient number. While this hampered the army's build-up before the war, the intensive use of these aircraft during the conflict rendered the transport fleet unserviceable for several months thereafter.[57]

This state of relative unpreparedness of the Indian Army and Air Force was a function of the government's calculation that China was unlikely to initiate a war because it was economically weak after the failure of the Great Leap Forward, diplomatically isolated given the rift with the Soviet Union and renewed tensions across the Taiwan Straits, and unprepared for a world war that was bound to ensue.[58] Under these circumstances, Nehru and his advisers believed